

separation between players, online meetings occur on a regular basis.

If you were to attend one such clam meeting, you'd probably find that the population is exclusively male—barely 0.5 per cent of the registered members on Kawabonka.com are female, out of which only a couple might have actually played a game online. Ricky knows a grand total of one female who plays multiplayer regularly.

Hard Facts

The hardware required for hosting a multiplayer game varies accord-

ing to the game that is played, the geographical distance between users, and the number of players expected to join. This last factor is the most important one to consider when you'll host a multiplayer session. As an example, a typical *Quake III Arena* game involves around eight players over a LAN. In such a case, the player with the fastest PC hosts the server and plays the game. There's no need for a dedicated server (a machine that only hosts a game and does not play it), as the connection type (LAN) and small number of players

are good enough for the server to handle frags with no lags!

There are various connection methods, and each of them can be used to play multiplayer games, provided that the specific game supports such connections:

LAN: This is probably the most widely used method of playing multiplayer games. Internet providers have begun to offer 24x7 connectivity to users through the means of a LAN controlled by a server. This has brought networks to residential areas—hotspots for gaming.

A LAN is located in a geographically small area, a few square kilometres at the most, but typically inside a building or group of buildings. This not only provides great access speeds (up to 100 Mbps) but also increases the social interaction. A great way to play multiplayer and have busloads of fun is to host a BYOCLP (Bring Your Own Computer LAN Party). The idea is simple: call everybody you know who has a PC—more the merrier. Get hold of a few network cards, an 8-port hub, and you have a LAN inside your own home.

The Internet: Next to LANs, this is the most popular multiplayer game type. You need to have an Internet connection to be able to join online servers, and a fast connection, at that. This rules out most of the gaming public in our country. The only way that people with

Set up your own Quake III Arena server over a LAN

Click on the Multiplayer menu in *Quake III* and click on Create to go to the server setup screen. Choose a map to play in. Scroll down to a map of your choice and click on it. Next, choose the game type and click Next.

In the next screen, select the number and type of players that will join your game. Open indicates that the slot is reserved for a human player, while selecting Bot will make a computer-controlled opponent join the battle.

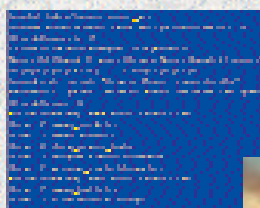
You can adjust the difficulty of the AI through the Bot Skill option.

The list on the right sets the server parameters. Frag Limit and Time Limit set the conditions for ending each round. A Frag Limit of 20 tells the server to end the game once a player achieves 20 kills, while a Time Limit of 20 will end the game after 20 minutes. Setting

any field to zero removes that limit.

The Dedicated flag controls whether the server can take part in the game. A dedicated server, once started, switches off the graphical display and merely hosts the game.

This method greatly increases the performance of servers running on slow machines, but you'll have one less PC to play with. Set



You can either set up a dedicated server (above) or otherwise enjoy a normal CTF game (right)



Pure Server to off to ensure compatibility with all machines, then choose a name for your server in the Hostname field. If you are playing in version 1.32, disable the anti-cheat program, Punkbuster. It's not required for LAN games. Click on Fight, and you're ready to rumble!